electricity supply was normal and we went to bed to the sound of the wind whistling past, rattling the doors and windows. Sometime past midnight, there was a loud screeching sound of metal being ripped off. I got out of bed, and by torchlight saw that the entire roof over the front part of our house, the drawing room and two bedrooms, including Amala's, had been torn away by the winds. I got Amala out of bed and into our bedroom, which fortunately still had a roof and we sat all huddled and wound up till daybreak, even as rainwater and debris steadily poured into the house. At daybreak, the winds subsided, the eye of the storm had gone past and we stepped out to the veranda to be met with a scene straight out of a disaster movie. Trees uprooted by the dozen, power lines flailing in the wind, the rain still coming down. Our house had about a foot of water inside by now, damaging all the furniture and fixtures. I surveyed the scene with dismay, wondering where to start and what to do. There was a huge coconut tree blocking the driveway, so I couldn't even take the car out. It wouldn't have mattered though, because all the roads were impassable to traffic. Since we all lived in the same compound, we clambered over and met in the counsellor, Manoj Bharti's residence and exchanged notes. Everyone's houses had been damaged to some extent or the other. One of the other officers had taken the added precaution of moving his car into the garage, but a huge tree had fallen on the garage itself, flattening the garage and the car, which later had to be sold as scrap. With all communications down, there was no way to contact the Ambassador, and more importantly, India, to tell them of our predicament.

The Indian Navy has a well-established SOP for the support of Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief (HADR) operations, honed through the experience gained in the relief operations undertaken by them in the aftermath

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